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A culture of constraints: How head coach turnovers affect the backroom staff and player development in professional football

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Abstract

In professional football, head coach turnovers are arbitrarily perceived as a shortcut solution to convert losing streaks into winning results within time-limited competitive seasons. Despite a speculative mentality guiding turnover decisions, a new coach is invariably appointed with the expectation of improving performance. As often overlooked, however, coaching replacements inevitably create unintended club-wide spillover effects. This study addresses two related club-wide research questions: (1) How do head coach turnovers affect player development at the team level?; and, (2) What are the spillover effects for backroom staff? Undertaken in Brazil, where turnover rates exceed those in Europe, 30 backroom staff practitioners (i.e., assistant coaches, goalkeeping coaches, fitness coaches, physical therapists, physiologists, and a medical doctor) completed semistructured interviews focused on their experiences. A reflexive thematic analysis revealed an overarching culture of constraints driven by conflicting behaviors and working practices. Three themes were highlighted at the team level: pragmatic playing style, methodological mismatch, and delaying team cohesion. At the individual level, four themes were identified: internal disruption, repetitive adaptations, job insecurity, as well as mental and emotional unrest. The findings indicate how within-season coaching turnovers represent a hazard that unintentionally constrains the mutual collaboration among the stakeholders directly involved with player development.

Keywords

Group dynamics, leadership, managerial succession, soccer, spill-over effect, team performance

Introduction

Head coaches in team sports act as leaders while collaborating with health and performance experts in a multidisciplinary framework focused on athletic development.[1,2] During the gradual process of team improvement, professional football coaches regularly assess their players' positional and behavioral data to design training sessions that may support their preferred playing styles.[3–5] More importantly, an effective football training process challenges head coaches to strike appropriate interventions for the development of team synergies sustained by nonlinear dynamics and adaptive systems.[6,7] Off the pitch, head coaches also seek to benefit from the intersection of load management and injury prevention strategies,[8,9] monitoring the recovery-stress balance to ensure that injured players return to competition only upon readapting to their optimal levels. Without this, players can experience reduced physical and technical performance.[10]

In practical terms, a continuous interplay exists between head coaches and their backroom staff, as their shared working—from service planning to delivery—impacts successful decision-making on player development.[2] To exemplify, whenever performance analysts provide data-driven support to assistant coaches, their insights are still susceptible to the final interpretation of their head coach. Looking at a different, yet intertwined, coaching domain, internal protocols are expected to be observed and respected across the collective workflow of physiologists, physical therapists, and fitness coaches whenever individual players are diagnosed with high injury risks. By reinforcing such ongoing procedures, optimal levels of internal communication can be decisive to improve player availability both in training and competition.[11] Given that head coaches share their work domains with backroom staff, replacing the head coach risks disturbing, changing, and/or interrupting established coaching routines that may reverberate across the day-to-day off-field team influences.[12,13]

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Although they operate within a complex, dynamic, and interactive coaching process whereby performance outcomes depend on the cooperation of their backroom staff along with contextual conditions,[14–16] head coaches remain somewhat misjudged by superficial metrics derived from winning or losing games. Consequently, it is common to witness club officials dispatching frequent head coach dismissals during the competitive season without substantial analyses about the ramifications of their decisions for the stakeholders who work directly with football performance.[17,18] As portrayed in Figure 1, head coach replacements tend to generate club-wide spillover effects due to the internal network connecting backroom staff domains.

Looking up the aftermath of football coaching changes, scholars have identified a decline in running performance after midseason turnovers in Brazil and Spain,[19,20] with only a limited improvement in Germany and Poland.[21,22] Meanwhile in English football, practitioners who experienced repeated managerial changes have reported behavioral and emotional reactions that deteriorate their trust, commitment, and motivation to work.[23] Overall, most of the literature has examined coaching turnovers through measures of game output (e.g., points, goals) and league ranking (e.g., winning percentage, ranked position) in a stream of statistical studies.[18,24,25] However, it is paramount to emphasize that even if players and teams can be analyzed with individual metrics that represent successful indicators, sport performance outcomes are predominantly relative to what happens around the team and its opposition.[6,7]

Behind the speculative mentality guiding football coaching turnovers, it is possible to acknowledge how the organizational level intentionally expects a direct effect (e.g., winning results) whenever a decision is taken to replace the head coach. Nevertheless, coaching turnovers unintentionally spring club-wide effects into the team (e.g., training rhythm) and individual levels (e.g., trust). This interplay among levels resonates with the concept of spillover effects, also known as trickle-down or cascading effects.[26,27] Essentially, after actions are manifested at an upper level, inevitable consequences spill over into lower levels of the organization.

From a theoretical perspective, this qualitative research explores the recurring instabilities of within-season managerial succession in elite sports organizations.[12,23] To ignite the rationale, this study understands that an organization not only represents a stable hierarchy but also a constantly changing social network whose stakeholders have information and influence to share, potentially shaping a flourishing and thriving system that may excel with positive outcomes.[28] Based on Quinn's[28] paradoxical approach, organizational tensions and oppositions tend to arise as part of an emergent process that challenges conventional assumptions through collective learning and creative collaboration, thus shifting the internal focus from organizational constraints toward possibilities for continuous improvement. That is, the reality of constraints is meant to leverage possibilities for transformation, as they convey building blocks worthy of human investment in the organizational culture.[28]

Treating a football club as a collective organism, this research examines the club-wide spillover effects between coaching transitions with an aim to demystify the reality absorbed by the backroom staff as head coaches move in and out of their jobs during the competitive season. By

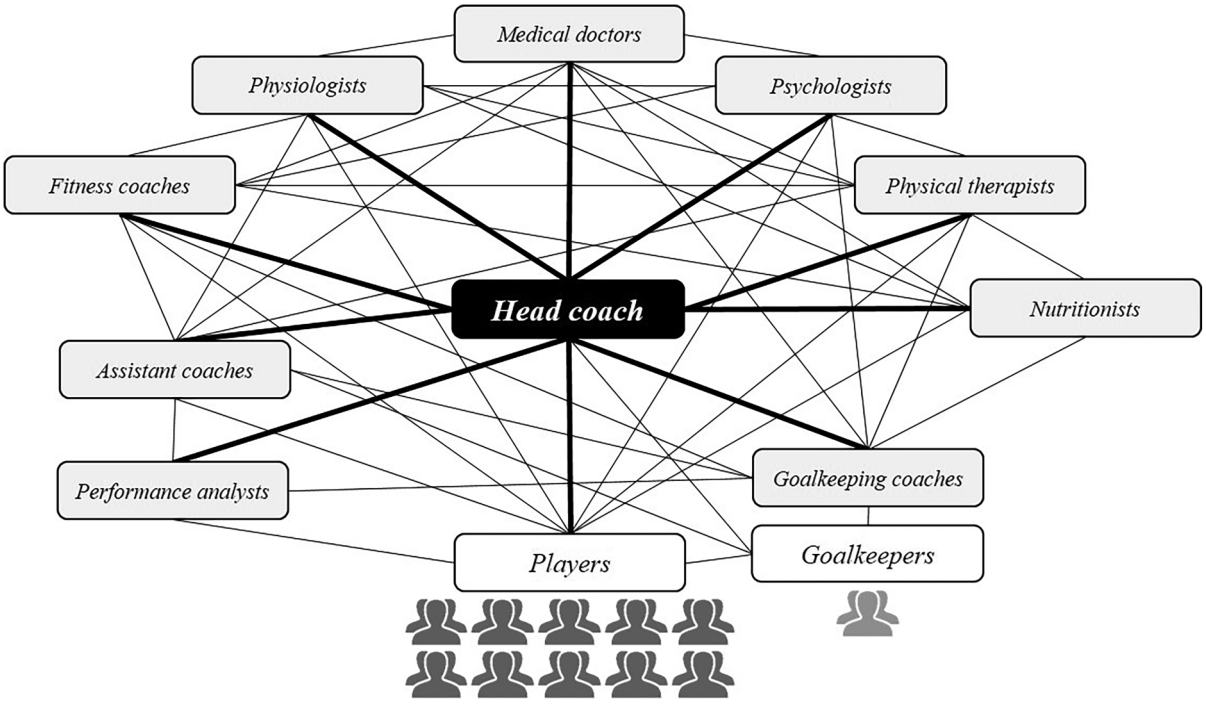

Figure 1. Typical network surrounding the head coach in a professional football club.

interviewing practitioners who directly participate in the coaching process, the present study moves away from statistical estimates and addresses the actual experiences of high-performance experts. Two research questions are asked: (1) how do head coach turnovers affect player development at the team level? And (2), as head coach replacements occur, what are the spillover effects for backroom staff? Inasmuch as volatile coaching spells may diffuse recurring instabilities into a football club, this qualitative study reveals how working routines are likely destabilized behind the scenes of midseason turnover events.

Research background

The present research is contextualized in Brazil's elite football, whose primary domestic league is known as *Brasileirão*. While referring to the Brazilian context, scholars have exposed how professional coaching practice could improve team behavior through technical–tactical variations,[3,29] as well as how strength and conditioning strategies could be reassessed during the competitive season.[30,31] Yet, a high degree of coaching volatility has been reported across the Brazilian territory due to absent managerial processes when hiring, evaluating, and replacing head coaches.[17] Driven by superficial decisions at the organizational level, coaching replacements in the *Brasileirão* are much higher in comparison to similar leagues from Europe, South, and North America, posing particular challenges to professional coaches who operate in Brazil.[16,24,25] To illustrate their reality, Figure 2 depicts the average coaching tenure for each *Brasileirão* season in the last decade.

Methods

Participants

Table 1 outlines the 30 backroom staff practitioners (mean age: 48 years; age range: 33–73 years) included in this study according to the chronological series of interviews that was carried out between January 14 and March 25, 2021. Fundamentally, the backroom staff represent a multidisciplinary team that supports the head coach to improve elite players' performance, comprising sports scientists, sports medicine personnel, and expert coaches.[1,2] For this research, particular attention was dedicated to attracting a reliable group of backroom staff who has experienced a multitude of within-season coaching turnovers in the Brazilian territory. All participants worked at least one year in the *Brasileirão* between 2011 and 2020. Though their careers are mostly grounded in Brazil, their professional background also combines high-performance expertise in foreign leagues (e.g., England, Spain, Japan, China, and Saudi Arabia) and international competition (e.g., CONMEBOL *Libertadores*, UEFA Champions League, Olympics, and FIFA World Cup). The interviewees

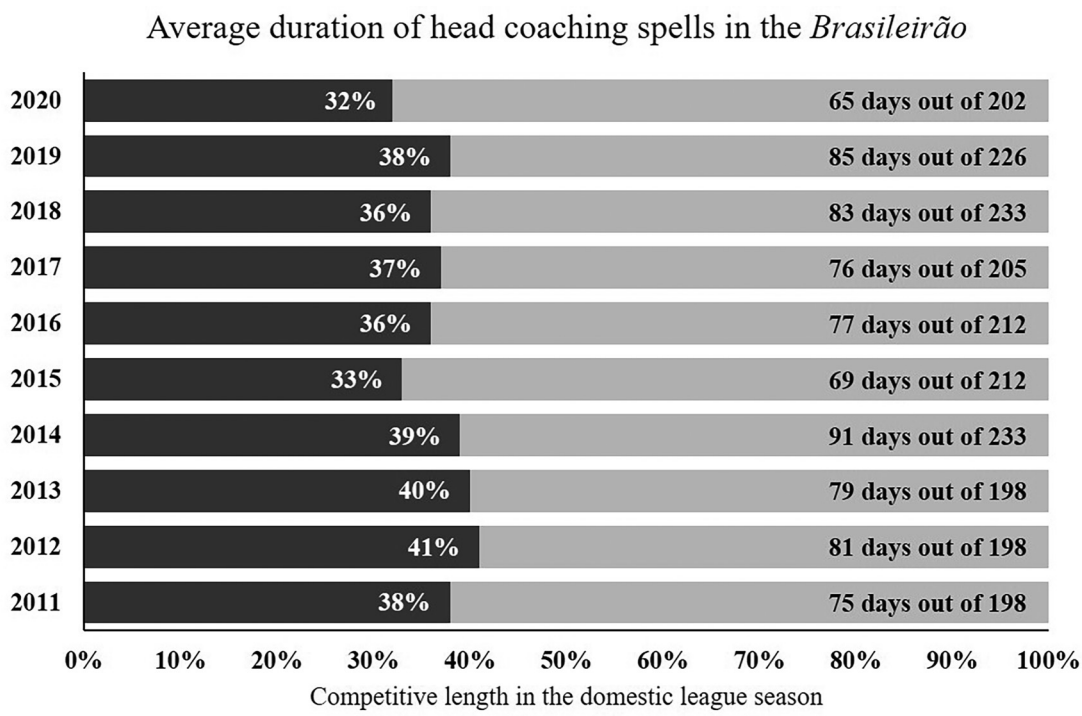

Figure 2. Average within-season tenure of head coaches in Brazil (2011–2020).
Note. Between 2011 and 2020, professional head coaches were employed for 78 days on average during the *Brasileirão*, representing 37% of its competitive length. This period includes a total number of 183 coaches and 34 different clubs.

Table 1. List of backroom staff practitioners interviewed for this study (in chronological order).

Staff ID	Role	Staff ID	Role
S1	Physical therapist	S16	Physical therapist
S2	Assistant coach	S17	Fitness coach
S3	Physiologist	S18	Medical doctor
S4	Assistant coach	S19	Fitness coach
S5	Assistant coach	S20	Fitness coach
S6	Assistant coach	S21	Fitness coach
S7	Assistant coach	S22	Physical therapist
S8	Fitness coach	S23	Fitness coach
S9	Assistant coach	S24	Goalkeeping coach
S10	Goalkeeping coach	S25	Goalkeeping coach
S11	Fitness coach	S26	Physical therapist
S12	Fitness coach	S27	Fitness coach
S13	Fitness coach	S28	Physiologist
S14	Assistant coach	S29	Physical therapist
S15	Goalkeeping coach	S30	Goalkeeping coach

consented to institutional ethics, whose procedure was approved by the hosting university (EUB-2022-026-S) and adhered to the Declaration of Helsinki, thus securing their anonymity.

Data collection

Semistructured interviews were held in Portuguese, transcribed verbatim, and translated into English for data analysis. Albeit the full interviews lasted on average 71 min, this study represents one section of a larger research project investigating different topics around elite coaching performance and turnovers. Specifically for this research, participants were inquired to talk about the spillover effects of within-season coaching replacements. Part of the semistructured questionnaire was designed to address the potential ramifications around player development, as well as their fallout on backroom staff domains. At the team level, these questions were posed: How do frequent coaching changes impact team development in practice? What happens to the players between transitions of head coaches? How does coaching volatility actually affect football team performance? Meanwhile at the individual level, they were asked: What are the side effects of coaching changes for your work as backroom staff? What happens to staff members between transitions of head coaches? How does a new head coach usually affect your job?

Data analysis

A reflexive thematic analysis was employed to interpret the qualitative data, thus allowing the authors to engage with an exploratory and interpretivist approach similar to existing sports-related studies.[1,32] Initially, the coding procedure identified data items using the written transcripts, which contributed to preliminary themes. Through a recursive and critical evaluation of the data, immersive themes were developed to better reflect an in-depth and detailed understanding of the analysis.[33] Within this immersion, the authors looked to contextualize, organize, and communicate a coherent pattern of shared meaning for each one of the final themes,[33,34] moving away from a deductive rules-based approach to capture the complexity of spillover effects into the team and individual levels of sports performance. Selected quotations were then adopted to portray the data trustworthiness.[35]

Findings

Figure 3 illustrates the themes which were established to sustain shared patterns of meaning across this qualitative inquiry. Albeit the interviewees identified a positive side of diverse interactions and experiences while working with a number of head coaches throughout their careers, the findings give prominence to the indirect and unintended spillover effects of turnover decisions in the midst of a competitive season.

Team level

Pragmatic playing style. Primarily, the practitioners acknowledged how continuous turnovers lead coaches to cultivate a sense of pragmatism on the pitch during their limited spells. Under a constant danger of being fired, "the head coach applies a rather pragmatic game to defend and take minimum risks" (S5). While endorsing such "a coaching behavior that is less creative, risky, and bold" (S2), they opt to play with simpler and safer options, originating "an ugly and defensive game" (S10). Presumably, coaches downgrade players' creativity and team evolution to implement a reactive game instead, which affects the flow of proactive information on the pitch. One interviewee summarized this turnaround:

> "I reckon coaches have an idea about working with concepts and behaviors to improve the team. Yet, as soon as the first negative results arise they don't concentrate their energy on team development, but rather on winning the next game to remain employed. This affects the quality of our game because without ideas, training, and time to mature we won't get better. They abdicate from improving players to focus on the week's result instead." (S14)

Methodological mismatch. Sudden within-season head coach replacements also tend to unbalance training methodologies, harming players' improvement due to deviations around coaching preferences and characteristics. Signaled by the practitioners, "there are clearly losses between opposite coaches" (S13) because players must cope with "different methodologies that affect their performance"

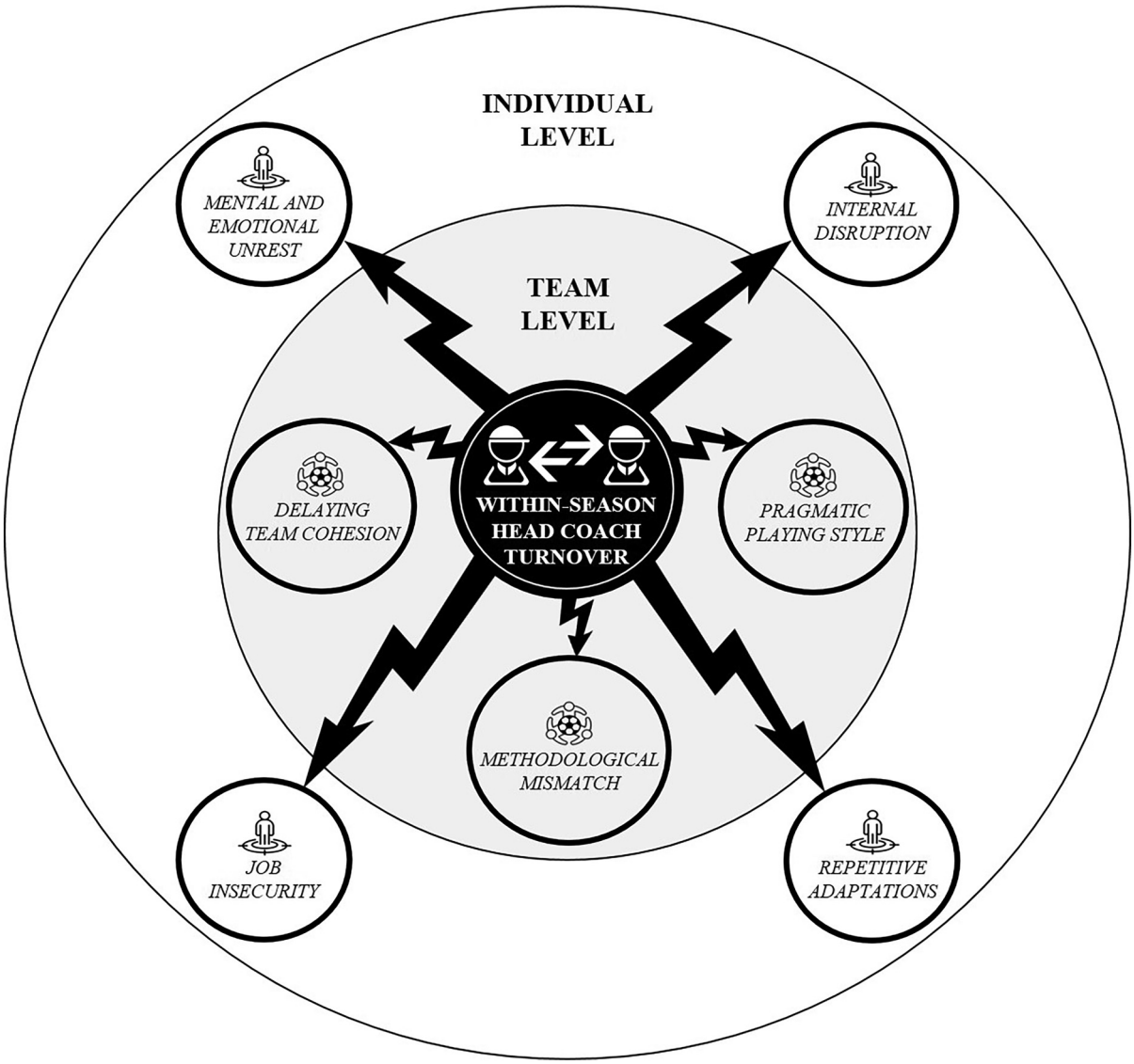

Figure 3. A culture of constraints: The club-wide spillover effects of within-season head coach turnovers.

(S3, S11, S19). Even with similarities, "it is a slow and dangerous process during competition" (S20) given the likelihood of radical shifts around methods and routines.

> "If a new coach executes a workout for his team to run faster within a short period of time, this approach might not sustain itself with a proper basis of preparation. And later, if another professional replaces him and understands otherwise, there'll be a structural loss. There'll be changes and muscular injuries because the neuromuscular demand was oriented when the athlete wasn't prepared for that. Therefore, it's a bit more complex." (S27)

The practitioners prompted the risk of neglecting their load management, as a within-season methodological variation may increase the incidence of physical complaints, fatigue, and injuries at short notice. Upon facing distinct training methods, "the athlete's body is the component that suffers because a switch of conduct reflects on the players' physical and cognitive states" (S18), "so if you increase the load due to a different game system, the consequences will be felt by the athletes' organisms as they're not yet ready for that demand" (S28). Another interviewee exemplified:

> "I see a major impact in the first weeks of a new coach because the athletes' routine changes completely. For instance, the former head coach only trained in the morning but now they practice in the afternoon, while the fitness coach switches from working in the gym to functional sessions on the pitch. Such impact with a new coaching staff is clear to me as the players' symptoms increase a

lot within my physical therapy demand. I catalog information about athletes entering and exiting our department, their frequency attending a preventive workout, so I can perceive the difference." (S26)

Delaying team cohesion. From a team performance standpoint, the substitution of head coaches is perceived as a dysfunctional and counterproductive measure to build synergy among players, as they predominantly work with a short-term mindset based on superficial relations. The backroom staff defended a consistent "sequence of practices, games, and feedback" (S7), otherwise "players are overwhelmed with different stimuli until they get accustomed to performing well in another playing style, game proposal, or individual role" (S29). "Team building requires time, even seasons working together, so when you're highly susceptible to being fired there's no significant group cohesion" (S2). Expressing concerns on how players' interactivity can be affected, one interviewee explained:

"A coach turnover returns players to a starting point, so a minority benefits, but this oscillation is much more damaging. It brakes the athletic evolution. One player fits, another doesn't. One has more or less affection, leading to a technical, physical, and tactical downturn. The loss of confidence and quality scares us to the point we wonder whether we're working with the same players as before." (S4)

Individual level

Internal disruption. Focusing on the backroom staff, their working practices are expressly disrupted when club officials allow new head coaches to take full control of the sports structure. After a replacement, the interviewees stated they must "convince the new coach about what's already established, reaffirming ideas and protocols" (S16, S26), which generates "an internal stress" (S21). Despite their attempts to implement institutional practices, if the incoming coach disagrees with their methods, "everything falls apart, and club officials care less about that" (S17). Acting with superior power upon arrival, "new coaches might claim the methodology and even the organizational chart are wrong, so changes must be made" (S22). Yet, it is paramount to defend the workflow and remind them how the backroom staff manage "medical antecedents, operations, injuries, and limitations that players present" (S18). To echo their reality, one practitioner shared the internal picture:

"There can be abrupt changes regarding routines and procedures. Either because the new coach doesn't believe in the role, equipment, technology, or ideas. He might disturb the environment with a lack of trust, a lower interaction, without loyalty and assistance. We must often talk about practices, meetings, athletes, trips, games, and mostly under moments of pressure. If relations aren't built by the leader, it's much more difficult to connect." (S3)

Repetitive adaptations. As coaching spells are interrupted and new appointments are made, the backroom staff are forced to continuously readapt at short notice. Underlined by the interviewees, they are at a "constant reset, always starting over" (S2), "adjusting the routine in the midst of competition" (S20). Understandably, "if three coaches work for the club during the year, that means three different ways to readapt" (S13). In practice, they must quickly learn how to handle a new coach "because some might require you to discuss everything in person, but others don't even want to talk to you" (S22). In face of within-season replacements, "the whole staff suffer to adapt to drastic changes of methods and human treatment" (S10). Metaphorically, one practitioner even argued they must "change the wheel while driving the car" (S7). Upon looking to fit with different leadership, relational preferences, and methodologies, frequent turnovers are perceived as "harmful" (S24), "unpleasant" (S25), and "stressful" (S21) by the interviewees.

"It interferes on our understanding about what new coaches expect. There's the type who wants an injured player back in training regardless of the situation. It's like: '*He can return and treat later, but I want him on the pitch.*' Then another coach only asks for players who are fully recovered. You need to comprehend how he thinks, and understand the influence of those surrounding him. So you're looking to gain everyone's sympathy again, and this is tiresome. It's exhausting to change a working strategy just to meet the expectations of a new coach." (S1)

Job insecurity. Drawing attention to occupational matters, the backroom staff get insecure about their own employment when coping with transitions of head coaches. The interviewees reported to be under relentless surveillance because "the incoming coach can suddenly dismiss anyone as if he were the club owner" (S5). To exemplify, "you don't know who the new coach will bring with him, if he wants you to continue, and how he'll evaluate you" (S1, S16, S22). Consequently, the risk of dismissal influences how practitioners "rethink attitudes to overcome the uncomfortable pressure" (S4) and "remain somewhat safer in the job" (S10). Due to such instability, they even question the development of their own careers outside of football. Especially for those who were not professional footballers, "nobody has financial stability to afford a family, paying the bills, so it affects everyone a lot" (S6). In hindsight, one interviewee encapsulated this vulnerability:

> "From the moment there's a replacement, it causes disquiet among club employees. You begin to question yourself: '*Could it be that my work or the methods I'm applying are neither ideal nor correct? Our team was leading the league and suddenly after three games it's the worst team?*' There's no parameter because you're moved by results. You're always worried there might be changes in every department. It's very difficult to work with such disturbance." (S30)

Mental and emotional unrest. Sequential head coach turnovers also trigger moments of restlessness in the personal lives of backroom staff. Considering their professional turmoil between replacements, one interviewee argued "football is inhumane in Brazil" (S4) as it messes with their private, social, and family surroundings. "The patterns of anxiety spill over because club officials release their pressure on us before approaching the coach" (S8). "It affects our emotional and affective side, our self-esteem drops" (S10), "with colleagues even showing lower immunity and falling sick" (S3). Collectively, the interviewees shared unhealthy experiences of self-doubt, sleep deprivation, and higher blood pressure, as well as the interference of their occupational stress being transported to family relations.

> "When I took over as an interim coach my life turned upside down. It's funny to tell you this because people have no clue about what happens. I wasn't sleeping or eating well. I could see how the pressure was high, how the environment got disturbed as I had to deal with all situations and problems. It's too much, and club officials hinder instead of helping us." (S9)

Discussion

Intrigued by the recurring instabilities that likely prevail within football clubs due to frequent and unsubstantiated head coach dismissals, this research aimed to disclose the club-wide spillover effects of midseason coaching turnovers in Brazil. Interestingly, even though the original expectation behind turnover decisions leans toward the belief of a shortcut to success, the insights from practitioners who have experienced multiple coaching transitions reveal the opposite direction for performance outcomes.

In the face of challenging constraints that may disrupt routines, backroom staff cultivate innovative ways to assimilate, adjust, and cope with the expected and unexpected disturbances in the coaching process. The scale and direction of these disturbances are driven by distinctive combinations of conflicting behaviors, working practices, and expectations at the individual and team levels of the organization. Fundamentally, within-season coaching turnovers shape a counterproductive culture of constraints, which can affect the mutual collaboration needed for better player development.

According to Quinn,[28] organizational leaders who trust the emergent process of collective excellence tend to empower human potential and foster authentic communication to support a positive organizational change. In this sense, a positive change for a football club would represent an opportunity to overcome preexisting, within-season competitive constraints. In effect, the head coach—who was initially appointed to lead the first team—would be trusted to also optimize the interactions of backroom staff across the organization. Here, "change" is not meant to be understood as replacing the coach or different backroom staff, which would quickly shift blame to a single person in the face of challenging scenarios. Instead, the "change" may relate to the realignment of attitudes and/or behaviors among club personnel. This can be perceived as one of the positive tensions that drive collective learning patterns. Regarded as a collective organism, the football club would thus represent a system of tensions that leverages possibilities, rather than a static entity blocked by constraints.[28]

Consistent with this rationale, the interviewees recognized that head coaches depend upon flourishing relationships, both on and off the pitch. To influence their teams' patterns of play and their desired competitive behavior in the professional football context, head coaches are expected to engage with fluid practices and training methodologies that offer a potential for building consistency within the club. However, when frequent midseason turnovers occur, the performance outcomes evidently demonstrate a contradiction between the ideal scenario advocated by practitioners and the actual disturbance triggered by volatile coaching appointments.

Given the state of urgency, impatience, and vulnerability in which professional football coaches operate, fundamental tensions emerge from different priorities between the incoming head coach and the backroom staff. While the new coach is expected to produce immediate signs of improvement, the backroom staff acknowledged that tensions arise due to their longer-term focus on player development. They also identified that, instead of turning tensions into possibilities, turnovers unintentionally create a culture of constraints for all stakeholders involved in the coaching process. In this kind of culture, self-protective behaviors around withholding power and control prevail among its leadership personnel. Often, this results in shaping an underperforming system as they are afraid to address new norms and internal pressures. Such a context downgrades the human potential for collaboration.[28]

As Cushion et al.[14] suggested, the continuity of a coaching process comes less from stability and more from the adaptability of interactions between agents and structures. Without mutual efforts between the leader and their internal network, it is unlikely that organizational constraints will

lead to possibilities of transformation through collective working. For example, the incoming coach might want to repeat players' selection across consecutive games, but the backroom staff must account for previous competitive demands alongside any extensive travel and lack of rest that combine to affect players' recovery between games. Likewise, a new coach might urge a recently injured player to skip transition and participate in intensive training sessions, whereas the backroom staff must uphold internal protocols to return the player to perform at optimal levels.

Although the backroom staff reinforced the need to inspect football players within a complex network of human behavioral interactions and movements on the pitch,[6,7] they also disclosed how incoming coaches lean on a defensive-minded game style as a conventional belief to avoid losing matches and protecting jobs.[5] Contradictorily, however, playing with a focus to defend generates less ball control and tighter spaces against the opposition, affecting the possibilities of creative movements with the ball to enhance offensive accuracy.[15,29]

Furthermore, as incoming coaches prioritize their own working preferences to reaffirm their hierarchical position, the practitioners warned that methodological shifts represent an unnecessary risk factor for player development. Particularly during the competitive season, Loturco et al.[31] have advocated for footballers to train under optimum load conditions as an efficient alternative to the classic strength-power periodization. Yet, the total training time and load are substantially affected in the Brazilian context, potentially leading to physiological stress, muscle damage, and increased injury risk.[30] Therefore, managing the training load stands out as a paramount aspect to support footballers' physiological and psychological recovery.[4,8] Whenever such club-wide priorities are undervalued due to within-season coaching changes, the narrow-minded impatience to force results inevitably compromises injury prevention strategies in the midst of competition.

By channeling the club-wide spillover effects into the individual level of practitioners, it becomes revelatory how midseason turnovers indeed represent a problematic phenomenon for the backroom staff both from professional and personal perspectives. Overall, the backroom staff feel multiply constrained by having less time, trust, and incentives than they need to address key tasks such as monitoring and instructing players, safeguarding internal protocols, and encouraging evidence-based decisions. This pressure is even compounded by particular challenges linked to the uncertainty of personnel selection, subjectivity in the coaching style, and methodological contradictions raised by volatile leadership succession.

Imminent threats are exposed as soon as they need internal buy-in from a newly appointed coach who exacerbates his resistance to ongoing practices, disturbing the quality of internal communication in the coaching process.[11] Detained by such a leadership behavior that limits human potential instead of leveraging it toward positive organizational outcomes,[26,27] it is plausible to recognize how abrupt coaching aims, opinions, and a sense of hesitation tend to impact interpersonal relations among the practitioners who look to preserve a level of internal consistency during the season.[1,2,23] Intriguingly, even the health conditions of club personnel appear to pass somewhat unnoticed to themselves and their organizational leaders as turnovers materialize, carrying out challenges that may threat their personal care over a prolonged period.[32] Besides, they could lead to potential symptoms of burnout, receding trust, and declining motivation.[23]

The notion of mutual learning and collaboration restarts with each coaching replacement. If the incoming coach centralizes decisions and articulates conflicting ideas, the backroom staff witness restrictions on their attempts to establish working routines, temporarily reprioritizing their responsibilities to fit into a new leadership regime. Moreover, the fear imposed by unfamiliar relations and power imbalance also disturbs practitioners on their efforts to build rapport with cautious disagreements.

In essence, the inevitable misalignment of working practices between the new coach and the backroom staff requires time as a key component to foster feedback loops toward integrative growth.[2,16] Nevertheless, the reality of a midseason coaching turnover offers time only as a renewable resource if short-term expectations for improved performance are convincingly met. Otherwise, practitioners seem to be aware that another coaching replacement is predictable, which will likely disrupt their tentative habits once again. Given how the backroom staff are able to anticipate this repetitive mechanism, they apparently revise their contemporary understanding of institutional practices by performing adaptive behaviors between leadership transitions. Whereas the club-wide spillover effects are neglected, the illusion of a shortcut to success is refreshed as head coaches come and go.

Conclusion

This study explored a prominent area of football performance through the lenses of an overlooked angle around head coach turnovers. By analyzing the club-wide spillover effects that unintentionally spread across the team and individual levels of the organization, substantial insights explained the hidden ramifications of midseason coaching changes on player development and backroom staff domains. Fundamentally, a culture of constraints imposed by conflicting working practices revealed how players tend to interact, train, and play the game whenever head coaches are replaced. Meanwhile, the backroom staff demonstrated how they are forced to cope with new leadership regimes that frequently challenge their longer-term commitment to building internal consistency with behavioral practices and routines in the club.

Although this research does not naively accommodate that replacements must be ceased in any team sport where leaders and personnel interact toward collective goals, it equips an experienced-based platform disclosing the collateral impact generated by midseason coaching changes. Therefore, organizational leaders could preferably advocate for an internal assessment of potential ramifications and consequences prior to any turnover decision, thus avoiding an unnecessary turmoil across the backroom staff domains that value club-wide priorities in the long run.

Practical implications

This research offers implications for organizational and sports coaching practices. First, avoiding a within-season head coach replacement most likely helps club personnel to strengthen the nonlinear dynamics of football team performance. Given that practitioners emphasized the importance of building and respecting routines, decision makers may further benefit from continuously stimulating internal practices among the stakeholders who are directly involved with player development. Second, club officials who are able to clarify their head coaches' roles, responsibilities, and methodological approaches potentially optimize not only the interactions among the backroom staff who contribute to the coaching process, but also the desired performance outcomes planned by the organization. And third, organizational leaders may look into sports psychology as a strategic and necessary means to support their club personnel during coaching transitions, thus caring for their health and well-being conditions in the face of recurring instabilities at work.

Limitations and future research

The present research identifies some limitations. First, given its qualitative nature, the experiences shared by the interviewees were solely based on their professional background. A potential follow-up exists as a means to examine contagion effects through network analysis, which could shed light on distinctive influences and exchanges exerted by the personnel surrounding the head coach. Second, future research could switch into a quantitative approach and look for statistical indications around injury rates, training intensity, and load monitoring between head coach transitions. And third, the study focused exclusively on midseason replacements. Comparing realistic scenarios that account for coaching turnovers happening between seasons could be another interesting avenue for future research.

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